

CAN GOD FURNISH A TABLE IN THE WILDERNESS?

TEXT: Psalm 78:9-29 “The children of Ephraim, *being* armed, *and* carrying bows, turned back in the day of battle. ¹⁰They kept not the covenant of God, and refused to walk in his law; ¹¹And forgot his works, and his wonders that he had shewed them. ¹²Marvellous things did he in the sight of their fathers, in the land of Egypt, *in* the field of Zoan. ¹³He divided the sea, and caused them to pass through; and he made the waters to stand as an heap. ¹⁴In the daytime also he led them with a cloud, and all the night with a light of fire. ¹⁵He clave the rocks in the wilderness, and gave *them* drink as *out of* the great depths. ¹⁶He brought streams also out of the rock, and caused waters to run down like rivers. ¹⁷And they sinned yet more against him by provoking the most High in the wilderness. ¹⁸And they tempted God in their heart by asking meat for their lust. ¹⁹Yea, they spake against God; they said, Can God furnish a table in the wilderness? ²⁰Behold, he smote the rock, that the waters gushed out, and the streams overflowed; can he give bread also? can he provide flesh for his people? ²¹Therefore the Lord heard *this*, and was wroth: so a fire was kindled against Jacob, and anger also came up against Israel; ²²Because they believed not in God, and trusted not in his salvation: ²³Though he had commanded the clouds from above, and opened the doors of heaven, ²⁴And had rained down manna upon them to eat, and had given them of the corn of heaven. ²⁵Man did eat angels' food: he sent them meat to the full. ²⁶He caused an east wind to blow in the heaven: and by his power he brought in the south wind. ²⁷He rained flesh also upon them as dust, and feathered fowls like as the sand of the sea: ²⁸And he let *it* fall in the midst of their camp, round about their habitations. ²⁹So they did eat, and were well filled: for he gave them their own desire;”

INTRO: In our scripture text Israel, who has been privileged to see first hand the mighty acts of almighty GOD is being reproved for their actions of unbelief!

In Verse Nineteen Jehovah is insulted because the people question

his ability and willingness to provide for them during the difficult times!

In this chapter they are reminded of the following facts;
The promise of GOD toward Abraham and his descendants!

The miracle of the sea being divided by an East wind!

The miracle of the cloud that gave direction by day, and the pillar of fire by night!

The miracle of water coming out of a rock, similar to that of an artesian well!

The miracle of the manna, corn, and quails! Notice in particular verses 23-29 **“Though he had commanded the clouds from above, and opened the doors of heaven, ²⁴And had rained down manna upon them to eat, and had given them of the corn of heaven. ²⁵Man did eat angels' food: he sent them meat to the full. ²⁶He caused an east wind to blow in the heaven: and by his power he brought in the south wind. ²⁷He rained flesh also upon them as dust, and feathered fowls like as the sand of the sea: ²⁸And he let *it* fall in the midst of their camp, round about their habitations. ²⁹So they did eat, and were well filled: for he gave them their own desire;”**

You talk about a people of privilege, the Children of Israel had a tremendous history of spiritual precedent! (They were truly a people born with a silver spoon in their mouths!) In Genesis 12 God told Abraham **“And I will bless them that bless thee, and curse him that curseth thee: and in thee shall all families of the earth be blessed.”**

Yet, after all of this, they questioned GOD with respect to his ability and willingness to sustain them in the tough times! Look at it, **Psalm 78:19 “Yea, they spake against God; they said, Can God furnish a table in the wilderness?”**

You would think that after all that GOD had done to them and for

them, this question would never have arisen!

I want us to take a little closer look at what they were really asking:

I. CAN GOD FURNISH A TABLE IN THE WILDERNESS?

A. I want us to look specifically at three words here;

FURNISH- Comes from the Hebrew word **ARAK** (aw-rak'), and means to arrange, put in order, or prepare.

TABLE- Comes from the Hebrew word **SHULEHAN** (shool-khawn'), and means to spread out a meal.

WILDERNESS- Comes from the Hebrew word **MIDBAR** (mid-bowr'), and means a desert.

B. I think we could paraphrase this verse to say, “**CAN GOD PREPARE A MEAL IN THE DESERT?**”

Now that's not too much of an insult unless you are the one who has done all of the other things for them that I have already mentioned, and now these very same people are asking whether “**GOD CAN PREPARE A MEAL IN THE DESERT?**”

I want you to bear in mind three things as I continue to preach tonight;

The word **PREPARE** here has more to do with GOD's willingness, than his ability! (I would rather my children say my dad is willing to help me but he can't, than to say my dad is able to help me but he is not willing to do so!)

These people know he can, they just don't know if he will!

The word **TABLE** here has to do with the temporal, finite things we can lay our hands on, the things we can see! **Philip. 4:19** “But my God shall supply all your need according to his riches in glory by Christ Jesus.”

The word **WILDERNESS** has to do with the tough times in our lives!

C. I guess my question is, how could these people who have been eye witnesses of such miracles ever doubt GOD for anything, much less a small thing like **“PREPARING A MEAL IN THE DESERT?”** David said, **Psalm 23:5** **“Thou preparest a table before me in the presence of mine enemies: thou anointest my head with oil; my cup runneth over.”**

But then I think about all I have been privileged to see GOD do in my life, and yet there are times I actually question whether he will do it this time!

II. CAN GOD FURNISH A TABLE IN THE WILDERNESS?

A. He has in the past!

In Matthew 14 he fed 5,000 men plus their women and children with
Five loaves and Two fishes!

John 5, Man at the pool of Bethesda - 38 years! Jesus told him to
“RISE TAKE UP THY BED AND WALK”, and he did!

The Ten lepers in Luke 17! Go show yourself to the priest!

Woman with the issue of blood in mark 5! 12 years!

I want to ask you tonight what does your **DESERT** consist of? Do you believe GOD has what it takes to meet your need? Do you believe he is willing to meet your need?